

Cricket Fielding Fitness: The Most Overlooked Skill in Age-Group Cricket

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Walk into almost any age-group cricket net session and you'll see hours poured into bowling actions and batting technique — and almost nothing dedicated to fielding conditioning. Yet fielders spend roughly half of every match on the ground, performing some of the most explosive, high-injury-risk movements in the entire game: sprinting flat out, diving, and firing the ball in at full effort, often off balance. A 2023 narrative review in the **Strength & Conditioning Journal** makes the case plainly — fielding deserves its own dedicated training program, not leftover time at the end of a bowling session.

Fielding isn't one skill — it's several, and they need different training

The review breaks fielders down by role, and the physical demands genuinely diverge:

- **Close-in fielders** (slip, silly point) need lightning-quick reflexes and reactive ability — the ball arrives fast, with almost no reaction time.
- **Inner-circle fielders** need strong reactive skills plus a powerful, accurate overarm throw for quick run-out chances.
- **Outer-circle / boundary fielders** need to cover up to 40 metres at high speed, meaning real sprinting ability, combined with an accurate long throw once they get there.

Training every fielder the same generic way misses the point. A boundary fielder who never does repeated sprint work, and a slip fielder who never trains reaction speed, are both undertrained for their actual job on the field.

Where the injuries actually happen

The research is consistent on this: the primary skills associated with fielding injuries are **catching, throwing, and diving**, with **shoulder and elbow injuries** the most common outcome. Awkward landings from diving stops or slides are a recurring injury mechanism — and it's rarely trained for deliberately, unlike a bowling action that gets coached and corrected constantly.

That gap matters more for younger players. Adolescent fielders are still developing the shoulder stability and landing mechanics that adult fielders have built up over years of match exposure — which is exactly why dedicated conditioning, not just more matches, is what closes the gap safely.

What the research says actually works

The review recommends building a genuinely well-rounded program around fielding — aerobic fitness, speed, acceleration, change-of-direction ability, agility, and both upper- and lower-body strength and power — combining traditional gym-based strength work with cricket-specific drills, rather than treating fielding fitness as something that just happens by playing more.

One especially useful data point: a controlled study on **under-19 professional cricketers** found that a structured **12-week core stability training program** produced significant improvements in both **throwing velocity and throwing accuracy**, along with better core endurance. Throwing — the single most repeated fielding action in any match — turns out to be trainable in a very specific, measurable way, not just something that improves with more overs in the field.

Three practical additions to any age-group training week

- **Train fielding positions specifically, not generically.** Boundary fielders need repeated-sprint and long-throw sessions; close-in fielders need short-reaction catching drills under time pressure. Ten minutes of position-specific work beats thirty minutes of generic fielding drills.
- **Build throwing power through the core, not just the arm.** A rotational core stability program — planks, rotational medicine ball throws, anti-rotation holds — directly improves both how hard and how accurately a player can throw, backed by measured gains in the U-19 research above.
- **Practice landing, not just diving.** A few minutes of controlled falling and landing mechanics (rolls, controlled dives onto mats) builds the shoulder and body awareness that prevents the awkward-landing injuries the research flags as the most common fielding injury mechanism — and it costs almost nothing to add to a warm-up.

The bottom line

Fielding fitness isn't a byproduct of bowling or batting training — it's a distinct physical skill set with its own demands, its own injury risks, and its own trainable improvements. Age-group programs that treat it as an afterthought are leaving both performance and injury prevention on the table.

This is exactly the kind of gap our conditioning programs at Kanhustle Fitness are designed to close — building fielding-specific speed, throwing power, and landing mechanics alongside bowling and batting work, not instead of it. If your training week has a fielding-shaped hole in it, let's fix that.

Sources

- [Strength and Conditioning for Cricket Fielding: A Narrative Review — Strength & Conditioning Journal \(NSCA\)](#)
- [Strength and Conditioning for Cricket Fielding: A Narrative Review — full text \(ResearchGate\)](#)
- [Effects of Core Stability Training on Throwing Velocity and Accuracy of Under-19 Professional Cricketers of Sikkim — Journal of Chemical Health Risks](#)
- [Injuries in Cricket: A Review — PubMed](#)